A Zero-Cost Freight Flow Explorer for Utah

FAF origin-destination flows, DuckDB-WASM, and deck.gl — no backend required

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The Freight Analysis Framework (FAF) is the go-to public source for how much freight moves between U.S. regions, by commodity and mode. It is also awkward to use: several releases with different zone systems, benchmark years and dollar bases, plus a forecast that skips 2025 to 2029. Answering "what moves in and out of Utah?" usually means downloading gigabytes and wrangling them yourself.

So I built an explorer that does the wrangling once and ships the result as a static site. Utah is the configured state; adding another is a one-file change.

1 Try it

The live app is embedded below. Click a mode, commodity, partner state or year and every chart and the map follow.

Open app GitHub

2 What it shows

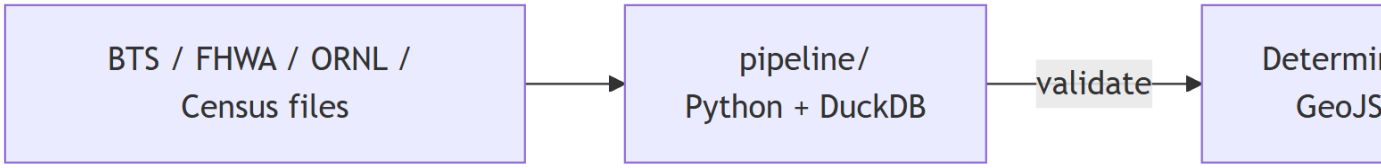
- **Origin-destination flows** in tons, value and ton-miles for every record that touches the state, by commodity, mode and year. FAF5.7.1 (2017 to 2050) and FAF6.0 (2022) are kept apart, never combined on one axis.
- **Forecast scenarios**: the mid-range forecast plus FAF5′s published High and Low scenarios, with forecast and preliminary years marked and the unpublished 2025 to 2029 shown as a gap.

- **Linked charts instead of tables**: direction, mode and commodity (treemap), the largest partner states, trends with the scenario band, a commodity-by-year heat map, and a two-year comparison. Clicking any element filters everything else.
- **The FAF5 truck network** with modeled link volumes, and clearly labeled **experimental county-level estimates** for 2022.

> ! Data and caveats only
>
> The app does not rank places, score performance, or present modeled values as measured counts. FAF flows are modeled estimates, and the app says so wherever they appear.

3 How it works

Nothing runs on a server. A local pipeline turns the raw federal files into Parquet, and the browser queries those files directly over HTTP range requests.



The pipeline is a small command-line tool run with uv:

```
cd pipeline
uv run python -m faf_pipeline update --state utah
uv run python -m faf_pipeline fetch --state utah --check-only
uv run python -m faf_pipeline validate --state utah
uv run pytest
```

Line 2

Fetch, build, zones, county estimates, network and validation in one go. It prints a changelog of what changed.

Line 3

Report changed files and new FAF releases without downloading anything.

Line 4

Run the checks that must pass before processed data is committed.

Line 5

Unit tests run on tiny fixture files for a fictional state.

Three design choices made the rest easy:

- **Deterministic output.** Re-running `update` on unchanged inputs produces byte-identical files, so a second run leaves no git diff and every data change is reviewable.
- **A schema guard.** Every downloaded file's columns are checked against a column map, so a new release that renames or drops a column fails loudly instead of quietly corrupting results.
- **No state literals in the code.** Utah appears only in `config/states/utah.yml`; validation fails if a state name, abbreviation or zone id shows up as a literal elsewhere.

4 Stack

Layer	Tools
Pipeline	Python, DuckDB, uv, pytest
App	Vite, Svelte 5, TypeScript
Maps	MapLibre, deck.gl, flowmap.gl, PMTiles
Queries	DuckDB-WASM over Parquet
Charts	Observable Plot

The methodology page lists every source file, release and caveat. The code is on GitHub — issues and PRs welcome.